

**Some pregnant women experience restless legs syndrome (RLS)**, whereby they have an irresistible urge to move their legs. It most commonly happens while resting, so can be very disruptive to sleep.

The exact cause of RLS isn't known but it may be related to an imbalance of a brain chemical called dopamine. The level of dopamine can be affected by a lack of iron. Restless legs syndrome will pass once you're no longer pregnant. To minimize the effects of restless legs syndrome:

- **Ensure your diet** includes an adequate intake of iron (see [Iron-rich foods](#)).
- **Take steps to get a good night's sleep.** Keep your bedroom cool, quiet, comfortable, and dark. Don't watch television, use a laptop, talk on the phone, or do any work in bed, and keep a consistent sleep schedule. Also, try doing something to challenge your brain before bed (a crossword puzzle, word jumble, or Sudoku puzzle). This may help ease your restless legs. Avoid exercising close to bedtime.